The Area and its History

Mauthen is a small mountain village with a population of 724 in the Gail Valley at the foot of the Carnic Alps. It is located on the border with the Italian region of Friuli. The road behind our house leads up to a mountain pass, and on the other side is Italy. Mauthen is also the town where Florian's mom and her sisters grew up.

The area has a rich history dating back to Roman times. During World War I, the mountains above Mauthen along the Italian border were the site of entrenched warfare. You can hike up to trenches and other remnants of the war perched high up in the mountains.

A room with a view (from a bedroom in the old part of our house)

The House and Town

Our house is located just behind the St. Markus Church (built in 1276) which features beautiful frescos and also has a nice organ on which we sometimes play. The foundations of the older part of the house date back to the 18th century while

the newer part was built as a bed & breakfast after World War II. We have renovated most of the house and there are plenty of bedrooms.

There is also a very big yard with apple, cherry and plum trees and space for kids to run. Florian's dad keeps his antique vehicles in a barn, which means you might find yourself riding a tractor, a small off-road military vehicle, or a vintage motorcycle!

Mauthen is also renowned for its many culinary delights, in particular meat specialties. There is also an organic vegetable farm and the award-winning Loncium microbrewery directly in town.

Mellow hiking…

For over 40 years Sissy Sonnleitner, one of Austria's most famous chefs, has cooked her award-winning Alpine-Adriatic cuisine at her restaurant Kellerwand which is just steps from our house.

… and not so mellow hiking!

Enjoying the Outdoors

Hiking, rock climbing, skiing, mountain biking, road biking, paragliding, canyoning, kayaking, swimming, tennis, … you name it. You can do it all here!

One of the main outdoor attractions is the "Karnischer Höhenweg" (KHW 403), also known as the "Friedensweg" ("Peace Trail") which follows the contours of the Karnischer Kamm mountain ridge that divides Austria and Italy, starting in the town of Sillian and ending after 150 km in Arnoldstein. This long-distance hiking trail traverse a highly diverse landscape with the complex geological forms of the Carnic Alps.

Walking in the Mauthner Klamm

The section east of the Plöckenpass is a bit longer and boasts a gentle landscape of hills with vast alpine meadows and easy hiking mountains. West of the Plöckenpass is the alpinistically more interesting part along the highest summits of the Carnic Ridge. There are several proposed stages, but many parts can also be done as day hikes.

Mauthen is also the starting point for many alpine rock climbing routes and some mellower alpine climbing crags. The "Mauthner Klamm", a deep mountain gorge, is within walking distance of our house and provides cool shade even on the hottest summer days.

A short illustrated history (in German) of alpinistic achievements in the area (featuring some of Florian's ancestors) is available here: http://faculty.som.yale.edu/florianederer/alpingeschichte_mauthen.pdf

The swimming pool

Swimming

There is a delightful natural swimming pool near the Valentin river, just a 7 minute walk from our house. The pool is naturally fed by a mountain river and it is very kid friendly! There is also shallower pool for little kids and a playground.

The Weissensee, Austria's highest alpine lake, is also around a 30 minute drive from our house.

Riding Bikes

There are plenty of biking opportunities: lift-assisted downhill mountain biking, world-class road biking on mountain passes featured in the Giro d'Italia, and wonderfully mellow biking along the Gail river. The Gailtal Bike Path is particularly beautiful because it runs through the valley with views of the surrounding mountains of the Carnic and Gailtal Alps. It runs slightly downhill and is even accessible for younger children.

View of the Gailtal bike path

Looking at part of the Giro d'Italia route after a short drive to Italy

Trips to Italy and Slovenia

Hop in the car (or onto the motorcycle) and drive up the Plöckenpass across the border to Italy. Venice is a little over 2 hours away!

Mauthen is also close to the Slovenian border. The picturesque Lake Bled can be reached in just 80 minutes.

Playtime

Outdoor chess is just one of the fun bonus activities in Mauthen. Walking to the local riding stables; biking to the organic farm; and picking plums in the yard to make jam are a few other highlights. Florian's relatives spend lots of time in Mauthen with their children and grandchildren providing visiting kids with a limitless supply of playing partners and toys!